

holistic HELP

* Paryavaran Evam Prodyogiki Utthan Samiti

Project Starting
self-help groups

Can-do Icon

Jayaprakash Narayan
for his Sampurna
Kranti movement

50 per
cent of the
agricultural
labour
households
are landless
and have
no assets



ON THE MARGINS: Hari Ram (right)
with his wife, Kamla, and farmers

For hundreds of labourers living in extreme poverty, an Allahabad-based NGO is the only hope of preventing them from lapsing into a life of bondage. There are no assets because there is no saving. There are no banks because there is no money to deposit. Driven to depending on moneylenders, they are invariably turned into little better than slave

labourers. The founder of the Paryavaran Evam Prodyogiki Utthan Samiti (PEPUS), Hari Ram, 50, has saved many such villagers, particularly women, in the districts of Allahabad and Pratapgarh, by helping them form self-help groups (SHGs). "Over 1,500 women in more than 100 SHGs have a revolving fund of Rs 7 lakh," says Ram.

Money is not the only help he provides. He believes in holistic development which is why long before the government got there, he went to the Chandauli villages, on the Uttar Pradesh-Bihar border, and started 20 informal education centres for rural children. There were no facilities for health, education or a public distribution system. By

1994, Ram had formed over 50 SHGs before he began work in the city and constituted two groups, the Gram Utthan Samiti and the Dalit Mahila Shakti Samiti. In 2007, he decided to focus on brick kiln workers. With brick kilns sandwiched between Allahabad and Pratapgarh districts, the PEPUS chairman realised many workers had died due to diseases and poor working conditions. PEPUS aligned with the Delhi-based The Energy and Resources Institute to train workers, particularly workers who fire bricks, to save them from diseases, reduce the pollution and save coal by adopting modern methods.

PEPUS has a financial tie-up with the Feet Society, Lucknow, and has divided the wives of brick kiln workers into self-help groups, comprising 105 women each. When they need money, the society gives a loan at an interest rate of 2 per cent to help set up a business. PEPUS remains a point of light for thousands of destitutes.

by Subhash Misra

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I will not rest till all the brick kiln workers are trained. It has altered their mindsets.

HARI RAM, Project Director, PEPUS

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